

# Cybermove: A Critical Practice on Virtualizing Our Daily Life

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## ABSTRACT

*Cybermove* prompts exploration of "housing". The artist used 3D scanning to virtually recreate her childhood room, packed all her belongings into two suitcases, and began her journey abroad. This digital space was then transported with the artist to a foreign country, unveiled and shared with visitors through a VR headset. The moving process was displayed on social media and connected with viewers' experiences of housing issues, amassing over 3 million views.

## CCS CONCEPTS

• Applied computing; • Media arts;; • Performing arts;;

## KEYWORDS

Cybermove, housing, Minimalistic life challenge, Social Media

### ACM Reference Format:

Jiahe Zhao and Liyu Chen. 2024. *Cybermove: A Critical Practice on Virtualizing Our Daily Life*. In *Special Interest Group on Computer Graphics and Interactive Techniques Conference Posters (SIGGRAPH Posters '24)*, July 27–August 01, 2024, Denver, CO, USA. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 3 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3641234.3671032>

## 1 INTRODUCTION

*Cybermove* is an action art project using virtual reality technology. The artist conducted a unique "move" in her room, eventually reaching the limit of the smallest living space. In this process, the discarded items were transformed through 3D scanning and stored in the virtual room. No matter where the artist goes, she only needs to bring light luggage and virtual reality equipment. Figure 1 was taken on *Cybermove*'s demo.

*Cybermove* advocates that "home" is not just a functional dwelling place. The material home that has been left behind in the past will be realized in the future. Using VR as a critical option of housing is the artist value proposition. This project was influenced by the minimalistic trend [Wikipedia, 2023,?], particularly a "minimalist life challenge" trend on social media after the pandemic outbreak [YouTube, 2023,?]. By posting her own journey on social media, *Cybermove* has received major exposure and raised heated conversation on the Internet.



Figure 1: *Cybermove* was shown at an exhibition.

The artist did not preset the purpose of moving, and the meaning of moving was clarified through continuous actions, especially by contemplating the feedback on social media.

## 2 IMPLEMENTATION

In this work, there are three important aspects. 1) Action art. The artist conducted a three-month cyber move, taking her packed luggage abroad and exhibiting her own room at the exhibition venue. 2) Virtual reality technology. The artist restored her childhood room by using 3D scanning technology. 3) Exposure and response. The artist published the creative process and results on social media, which aroused heated discussions on social housing crises, real estate bubbles, etc., and enhanced the artist's thoughts on the "minimalist life challenge" on social media.

The moving process can be organized into three steps (which is shown in figure 2):

### Step 1: Downsizing - Scanning and Discarding

The artist downsized her 12-square-meter childhood room three times, discarding items and scanning the room and objects into 3D models using her phone. Each move, to a 9, 6, and finally 3 square meter space, required her to reevaluate her possessions, keeping only essentials like bedding and digital products.

### Step 2: Packing - Virtual Restoration

She packed these into two suitcases. Utilizing the 3D models in Blender, she created a VR space replicating her original room and a virtual storage room for discarded items, which she also animated. Throughout, the bed remained fixed, allowing for a seamless VR experience.

### Step 3: Unpacking - Various Exposures

The artist's two suitcases were carried with her to an art festival where she recreated her living space in a show room. She documented all her creative processes and published them on self-media platforms in mainland China (Bilibili, TikTok, Xiaohongshu), receiving more than 3 million views. Figure 3 shows the reviews received on these social media.

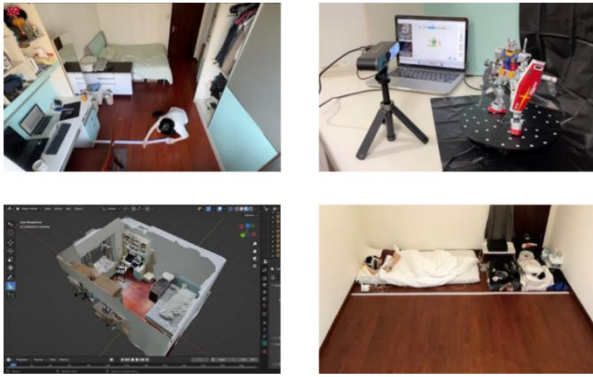
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SIGGRAPH Posters '24, July 27–August 01, 2024, Denver, CO, USA

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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-0516-8/24/07

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3641234.3671032>



**Figure 2: Marking out the area that stayed. Using scanner to scan items to be discarded. Inputting 3D objects on the computer and adjusting their locations. The virtual room is created.**

### 3 CONCLUSION

*Cybermove* resonated with viewers' struggles with the proposed minimalist lifestyle and their desire to escape the oppressive housing crisis. This shows that *Cybermove* has the potential to stimulate critical thinking and raise a variety of conversations. It highlights a problematic minimalist thinking rooted in consumerism (capitalistic accumulation) [Meissner, 2019].

Some netizens remain skeptical about virtual relocation replacing existing lifestyles, believing that virtual reality technology cannot replace real life. Admittedly, virtualization has its imperfections,

current technology can only simulate through digital reproduction, getting infinitely close to our real life. However, this is precisely where virtualization can be developed, as a capability to rethink modern life through simulation. Using virtual reality technology for creation changes the artist's view of "home". "Home" is not just a living space, but also the starting point and foundation of growth. Past objects and memories are "copied" into virtual space, which is in itself a recollection and manufacturing of memories. More importantly, through this virtualization behavior, the artist makes a promise to be fulfilled in the future. "Home" is a place that must be left, but also the final place to return to.

*Cybermove* does not advocate replacing or even eliminating real things and real homes with artificial ones. It is a product of seeking a compromise when facing life's obstacles, encouraging viewers to pay attention to the limitations of traditional dwellings. The notion of "dwelling" or "home" is now associated with functional spaces for engineering, management, and production. *Cybermove* is an ongoing project that aims to discover the fading concept of "home" through virtualizing movement. Virtualization is actualization. It's merely a possibility, not about probability. To virtualize is to allow a seed to grow into something. It's already present in the growing seed.

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Figure 3: The process video was share online, receiving reviews on Bilibili, Xiaohongshu and Tiktok.